

THEOSIS

Summary

Theosis, also called **the Gilded Suspension**, is the corporate homeworld and intersystem headquarters of **Erbium Industries LLC**. About 1.86 billion people live in sealed cities suspended in its sulfur-dioxide atmosphere. The air inside provides much of their lift; machinery and maintenance crews keep them balanced, supplied, and at a safe altitude.

Erbium established its permanent headquarters here after the destruction of **Wander**. It governs through the Theosis Directorate and controls most of the infrastructure residents depend on for housing, employment, and life support. Municipal councils have their own powers, though their work depends heavily on corporate funding and equipment.



The Gilded Suspension

Gravity Approximately 0.59 standard gravity; inhabited districts generally maintain between 0.6 and 0.9 standard gravity through local stabilization

Atmosphere Approximately 1 bar of sulfur dioxide outside the cities; breathable and mechanically regulated within inhabited envelopes

Day 11,760 stamp-offset minutes, divided locally into eight 1,470-minute civic bands

Year 1,322,496 stamp-offset minutes, approximately 918.4 standard days

Government Erbium Industries corporatocracy administered through the Theosis Directorate, Assembly of Envelopes, Common Altitude Board, and local Envelope Councils

Capital Crown Meridian

Corporate Headquarters Erbium Central

Population Approximately 1.86 billion; primarily human and dwarf, with substantial communities from throughout the Settled Systems

Languages Common, Dwarven, and most major Settled Systems languages

Religions Star Dream civic traditions, Wander memorial observances, corporate continuity doctrine, Vuddarian stewardship practices, industrial oath traditions, and imported Settled Systems faiths

The stars of Alpha Leonis illuminate Theosis's yellow-gray cloud cover. Its inclined retrograde orbit and extreme axial orientation produce unfamiliar stellar paths and angles of illumination. The cities become visible during descent through the upper atmosphere: lifting envelopes supporting habitation blocks and industrial infrastructure across kilometers of reinforced structure.

Whole districts occupy separate pressure compartments, linked by enclosed freight rail bridges. Docking towers reach into calmer atmospheric bands. Tethered maintenance crews work outside the hull, where winds can tear unsecured equipment from its mountings.

Arriving vessels normally stop at **Theosis Way Station** for customs and atmospheric-entry checks. Descent craft dock at hardened transfer towers above the inhabited envelopes. Passengers pass through decontamination and acclimation before entering city transit.

A CAPTURED WORLD

Theosis follows a steeply inclined, retrograde, eccentric orbit within the shared gravitational structure of Alpha Leonis B and C. Atmospheric planners track all three major stars, with local forecasts concentrating on the smaller pair and Theosis's barycentric path. The planet has a radius of approximately 6,950 kilometers, a mass of 4.22×10^{24} kilograms, and surface gravity of 0.59 standard. Its weak magnetic field requires the cities to prepare for stellar storms and shield their residents and equipment.

The atmosphere is almost entirely sulfur dioxide at approximately one bar. There is no established natural biosphere or open hydrosphere. Sulfur plains and volcanic rock lie beneath the clouds. Corrosive weather rapidly degrades surface mining and research equipment, requiring frequent repairs. Permanent habitation remains dangerously impractical.

Legally, Theosis is still **Alpha Leonis Captured Moon Four**. An early survey database registered captured barycentric bodies as satellites, including those without a parent planet. Correcting that designation would require amendments to centuries of municipal and corporate records. Erbium standards authorities acknowledge the obsolete astronomy and retain the name for technical interoperability. Residents usually call Theosis a planet; official business uses the legal designation.

TIME ON THEOSIS

A rotation lasts 11,760 stamp-offset minutes, or 196 standard hours. Civil systems divide it into eight **civic bands** of 1,470 minutes, used to schedule city operations and local life. The bands fall into four traditional periods:

Period	Principal activity
Rising Operations	The main work and school schedules begin.
Full Operations	Most administrative and commercial work takes place.
Dimming Operations	Services rotate, lighting dims, and part of the population begins its main rest cycle.
Quiet Operations	Maintenance and overnight city operations predominate.

These periods track administrative demand independently of sunrise. Districts and professions operate across all eight bands, and residents sleep on schedules much shorter than the natural day.

Erbium's intersystem administration uses a 1,440-minute standard day. Each local band runs thirty minutes longer, so corporate employees often keep local, corporate, and raw-stamp schedules. Work can cross payroll days or service-credit boundaries, and an atmospheric deadline can conflict with a corporate filing window. During relay interruptions, disagreements between local logs and the recognized stamp authority can leave completed work recorded as ghost minutes.

Dwarven **forge watches** overlap to provide continuous structural coverage. Technical and emergency crews sign their watch records. Clan archives retain copies independently of the corporate stamps.

An orbit lasts 1,322,496 stamp-offset minutes, approximately 918.4 standard days. About twelve and two-thirds local orbits fit into a standard lapse. Local years govern civic life and atmospheric planning. Intersystem law and corporate records use **Post-Erbium Standard**.

BEFORE THE STAMP

Theosis was surveyed in the first centuries of the interstellar era, after the **Star Dream** connected the early Elect civilizations and long before PES. Early probes found surface conditions commercially unsuitable for settlement.

Erbium engineers proposed suspended habitats. Breathable air weighs considerably less than sulfur dioxide, allowing a large sealed habitat to use its interior atmosphere for lift. Ballast and powered stabilization would manage the remaining load and control its position.

The first installations were publicly described as research and transport facilities. Their archives, reserves, and executive housing also equipped them to sustain corporate operations in an emergency. Erbium was evaluating Theosis as a corporate continuity site before Wander's destruction.

Official histories describe ordinary disaster preparedness. Independent historians note that company records, strategic reserves, and the resources to build a permanent settlement arrived before the public understood the severity of Wander's instability. The facilities could preserve Erbium's operations but lacked the capacity to evacuate Wander's population.

THE SECOND HOME

Construction convoys left for Theosis within months of Wander's collapse. They carried corporate personnel, dwarven construction crews, and displaced workers. Refugees were selected for technical or political usefulness. Temporary platforms became permanent pressure habitats, connected around shared frames. Within a generation, the largest installation had become **Crown Meridian**.

Its oldest compartments supported atmospheric research and the administration of Erbium's surviving operations. The company moved its formal headquarters there during early reconstruction, followed by its central departments and senior technical institutions.

Erbium offered refugees passage and the means to settle on Theosis through company employment. Most arrived under emergency employment agreements. Housing depended on service, equipment was leased, and transport became debt. Leaving company infrastructure meant exposure to the atmosphere outside.

Worksite administration developed into municipal government, with corporate departments taking responsibility for civil affairs. The same company established the settlements, employed their residents, and administered their government.

THE WAR OF THE OPEN STARS

Theosis had been Erbium's headquarters for generations when Zakaron began expanding. During the **War of the Open Stars**, Crown Meridian coordinated coalition logistics, financing, and diplomacy, including refugee transport and erbium allocation. The hostile atmosphere restricted unauthorized entry, Erbium controlled the cities, and the relay network was among the most secure outside Wander's former system. Its legal offices already handled agreements between governments dependent on corporate infrastructure.

New aerostats accommodated refugees and the expanding military support workforce. The Still-Drive negotiations used Theosis's legal, financial, and communications systems. When the **Still-Drive Accords** took effect at **0:00000000 PES**, Erbium activated the universal time standard through its relay network. The agreement ended Zakaron's expansion and established Erbium's position as interstellar timekeeper and legal convenor, with Theosis as the administrative center of the peace.

THE PES ERA

During the first lapses after the Accords, existing technical standards and corporate, municipal, and intersystem agreements became the earliest **Settled Systems Administrative Code**. Its expansion required a growing bureaucracy. Crown Meridian specialized in law and finance, while other cities developed technical and public-service institutions.

In Lapse 7, three linked habitation compartments lost structural synchronization during periastron atmospheric compression. Crews saved the central city by detaching two districts. More than eighty thousand people died during the descent. The resulting Code **A1%8&14-7**, the **Pressure-Envelope Inspection Record Standard**, requires compatible stamped maintenance histories for certified pressure-envelope and structural safety systems. Comparing parts and repairs across manufacturers has prevented further failures, though work documented solely outside recognized stamp systems may be rejected as unverified.

In Lapse 18, a stabilization failure put several cities on converging altitude paths. Authorities diverted a populated industrial district into a lower band to protect three larger settlements. It survived nearly four standard days before its envelopes failed. Code **A9%6&12-2**, the **Aerostat Compartment Separation Authority**, now permits designated infrastructure officers to detach parts of a city that credibly threaten the larger inhabited system. The power has saved millions. Lower industrial districts carry much of the city's weight and are most often selected for detachment.

By Lapse 29, Theosis is among the wealthiest and most politically influential worlds in the Settled Systems. City operations require continual calculation, certification, and financing of their survival margins.

THE BUOYANT CITIES

Breathable air supplies the cities' principal lift by displacing heavier sulfur dioxide. Heated lift chambers, ballast, and powered stabilization control movement and compensate for changing loads. Capacity planning balances a city's lift against its structural and life-support requirements, including emergency evacuation. Spacious rooms add lift and membrane upkeep; dense industrial compartments add weight and power demand while housing equipment that keeps the city aloft.

Large cities join several envelopes, each divided into pressure compartments that can be isolated during a failure. Emergency pressure barriers and breathing equipment are installed throughout public spaces.

Dist rict	Facilities and living conditions
Upp er	Stable buoyancy bands, prestigious institutions, and quiet, expensive housing. Pressure systems are newer and have extensive backups.
Mid dle	Most residential neighborhoods, local commerce, and public services, alongside workshops and food production. Families can occupy the same compartment for generations under renewable occupancy credentials.
Low er	Heavy industry and the machinery that maintains city altitude and life support. Housing is cheaper and more exposed to equipment failures, contamination, and evacuation.

Code **A4%7&14-3** , the **Pressure-Rated Habitation Eligibility and Transitional Continuity Provision**, requires each resident of a certified compartment to hold an employment, dependent, educational, medical, civic, or private sponsorship category. These records support evacuation and life-support planning. They also allow Erbium and affiliated landlords to end housing eligibility when employment ends.

Separated employees are entitled to a transitional review, but safety, identity, capacity, and sponsor-verification exceptions can shorten it. A worker can retain planetary residency while losing permission to occupy their housing compartment. Ownership and certification of air systems, altitude allocations, and housing are closely connected.

THE SHREDDER PASSAGE

During **periastron atmospheric compression**, or the **Shredder Passage**, Theosis's eccentric orbit causes rapid changes in stellar heating and atmospheric circulation. The planet remains gravitationally intact. Cloud layers expand, contract, and shift altitude; winds strengthen, and adjacent bands develop dangerous shear. Cities rebalance and reposition themselves to follow the moving buoyancy zones.

Preparations start thousands of minutes before the forecast approach. Crews secure exposed structures, rebalance the city, and prepare its emergency systems and rescue fleet. Unnecessary movement is restricted.

Code **A5%11&9-4**, the **Periastron Port Suspension and Atmospheric Docking Restriction**, suspends ordinary atmospheric arrivals, departures, and external intercity docking during declared Shredder conditions. This prevents collisions and dangerous loads on docking structures. It also strands travelers and delays essential deliveries. Displaced employees may be unable to reach their registered housing.

Upper districts offer sheltered viewing galleries and public broadcasts about the passage, while employees work remotely. On lower decks, residents hear stabilizers changing load and cargo straining against restraints. Pressure doors stay sealed for extended periods, crews sleep at their stations, and families keep masks ready.

Dwarven forge watches handle much of the structural preparation and emergency engineering. Code **A4%5&18-6**, the **Periastron Continuity Labor Designation**, allows the government and certified operators to reassign qualified staff, extend coverage, change rest schedules, and restrict departures during a declared recurring hazard. It requires medical monitoring, replacement crews, and hazard compensation. Erbium classifies many Shredder duties as ordinary work for infrastructure personnel, leaving those employees on standard pay for conditions that earn other workers hazard premiums.

THE ERBIUM CORPORATOCRACY

Erbium governs Theosis through the same executive structure that runs the company. Corporate and planetary authority remain legally separate for accounting, treaties, and jurisdiction. The company appoints the planetary executive and controls the main public institutions and budgets. Its ownership of essential infrastructure and Crown Meridian's main housing portfolios gives it authority over much of daily life. Erbium also controls professional licensing and technical certification, including the standards its own equipment must meet.

Officials call this a **stewarded corporatocracy**, arguing that the institution maintaining the cities needs authority to coordinate them. Critics object to the company's control over both government and essential services.

THE THEOSIS DIRECTORATE

The **Theosis Directorate** is the planetary executive. Erbium's governing board appoints the First Director, who usually also holds a senior corporate operations position. Other officials are drawn from corporate, municipal, and professional institutions.

Its responsibilities cover planetary administration, public services, infrastructure regulation, and intersystem relations. Its strongest powers apply to infrastructure continuity, a classification broad enough to cover most major political issues on Theosis.

THE ASSEMBLY OF ENVELOPES

The **Assembly of Envelopes** is the planetary legislature. Recognized aerostats receive representation according to population, certified habitation volume, infrastructure contribution, and corporate charter status. Local Envelope Councils choose most delegates. Erbium appoints additional corporate representatives. That bloc usually lacks enough seats to govern alone, but passing any law requires some corporate support.

The Assembly legislates on municipal affairs and public spending, including worker protections. It can reject Directorate proposals, investigate failures, and attach conditions to spending. The Directorate can suspend measures it finds incompatible with essential infrastructure, corporate charters, recognized Settled Systems standards, or another aerostat's safety.

THE COMMON ALTITUDE BOARD

The **Common Altitude Board** coordinates atmospheric traffic and safety, including Shredder preparations. Its technical and administrative members are appointed by the Directorate, Assembly, professional boards, and major cities.

Poorly coordinated cities can endanger each other, giving the Board broad operational powers. Assigning a city to a lower or less stable band may protect its neighbors at considerable physical and economic risk to its residents. The Board describes its models as objective, although their coverage depends on which populations and structures the government recognizes.

ENVELOPE COUNCILS

Each aerostat has an **Envelope Council** responsible for local services, development, and emergency planning. Some are directly elected; others divide seats among residents, property owners, clanholdings, worker associations, and corporate charter institutions.

Councils can protect residents during labor and housing disputes, fund public services, and resist development. They can also keep independent records, though their funding and means of enforcement depend largely on Erbium.

ERBIUM CENTRAL

Erbium Central, in Crown Meridian's upper structural core, houses both the corporate headquarters and planetary administration. It contains Erbium's governing board, the Directorate, and the central corporate departments. These include Frontier Extraction Division command and the authorities overseeing erbium reserves, PES, and Drift infrastructure. The Council of Settled Systems Administration meets here in Concordance Hall.

The public campus has pale stone interiors and controlled gardens, with service access hidden from visitors. Thousands of technicians work below it to maintain the headquarters' infrastructure, much of it built over successive generations. The illuminated headquarters emblem stays on through Shredder conditions until the highest power-preservation emergency classification.

Corporate policy can become planetary regulation without approval from an outside sovereign government. Practices developed here frequently become intersystem standards.

THE COUNCIL OF SETTLED SYSTEMS

ADMINISTRATION

The **Council of Settled Systems Administration** drafts, negotiates, and amends the **Settled Systems Administrative Code** in Concordance Hall. Recognized governments send delegations. Its provisions become binding through treaties, interoperability agreements, infrastructure licenses, local adoption, and the practical requirements of intersystem trade.

Erbium holds a permanent vote through the **Infrastructure Stewardship Seat**. Code **A8%10&5-2**, the **Essential Infrastructure Stewardship Representation Provision**, guarantees representation to the recognized operator of relay synchronization, strategic erbium reserves, PES administration, and shared transport standards. Its stated purpose is technical participation by the institution responsible for implementation. This gives Erbium a direct vote on laws governing its own operations and authority.

The Directorate and Assembly also select a Theosis delegation. Erbium influences the Council through both delegations, its technical staff, and other governments' dependence on corporate infrastructure. The company maintains that the seats represent separate legal interests; other governments object to its multiple representation.

POLITICAL TENDENCIES

Group	Membership and position
Board Continuity Caucus	Corporate leadership and established political and financial interests, including ladder families. Supports centralized administration, extensive continuity powers, and integrated corporate government. Argues that unified authority allows the rapid decisions needed to keep Theosis habitable.
Municipal Envelope Bloc	Elected councils from major cities. Accepts Erbium's planetary sovereignty and seeks greater local control of public services and budgets.

Group	Membership and position
Holding Compact	Dwarven clanholdings, independent engineers, professional inspectors, and skilled-worker associations. Seeks guaranteed repair funding, public maintenance records, stronger inspectors, and limits on craft-warrant liability.
Breath Commons	Advocates a civic right to breathable habitation, residency independent of employment, publicly sponsored life support, transparent capacity data, and limits on housing removal during labor disputes.
Free Altitude League	Semi-independent aerostats and small cities. Seeks municipal autonomy with central coordination of atmospheric safety.
Code Reform Delegation	Local reformers, foreign delegates, independent legal scholars, and Erbium officials concerned about the Code's legitimacy. Opposes the permanent Stewardship Seat and Theosis's effective double representation.
Public Systems Front	Advocates worker and municipal control of essential infrastructure and public housing. Technical members have detailed transition plans; a radical wing calls for a planet-wide refusal of labor to force the transfer.

HUMANS OF THEOSIS

Theosis has one of the largest human populations in the Settled Systems. Human **ladder families** dominate many upper-district institutions and senior administrative positions. Their children receive excellent living conditions and education, with access to the networks that control senior employment. Some families established their position through continuity transfers before Wander's collapse and helped define the qualifications that still govern advancement. Corporate accounts attribute their success to family discipline and qualified leadership.

Most humans work in city maintenance, public services, and routine administration. Corporate media favors successful officials as evidence of fair advancement. Workers elsewhere in the Settled Systems also associate Theosis with exhausted technicians whose families can lose pressure-rated housing after a missed shift.

Generations in reduced gravity are often taller and more lightly built. Exercise and medical treatment for the effects of reduced gravity are routine. Upper districts provide extensive preventative care; lower-deck workers depend on employer clinics and continued eligibility for treatment.

DWARVES OF THEOSIS

Dwarves are the second-largest ancestry population. Crews arriving after Wander's destruction built much of the structural and safety infrastructure still used in the oldest cities. Their technical institutions are among Theosis's oldest.

Clanholdings combine residential and working space with communal institutions and support services. Overlapping forge watches cover the full local rotation. Clan archives retain maintenance histories after the companies and computer systems that originally recorded them have ceased operating. Engineers sign their work with names and clan marks, including inspections that resulted in refused approval.

Code **A3%8&16-5**, the **Certified Craft-Warrant Liability Allocation**, treats those marks as evidence that a qualified professional accepted responsibility for the condition disclosed at inspection. It was intended to stop temporary contractors disappearing after approving unsafe work. Erbium and Directorate courts can hold engineers or clans liable for later failures even when management rejected repairs, substituted materials, altered stamped records, or exceeded the disclosed service limit.

Inspectors increasingly preserve independent, witnessed evidence of their work. Compliance offices accept these as supplemental evidence while giving authority to the corporate stamp. Some holdings see close cooperation with Erbium as essential to their members' survival and prosperity. Others maintain independent services and off-stamp archives to reduce that dependence. Most large clans include both positions.

OTHER RESIDENTS

Every recognized Settled Systems ancestry has established communities here. Their work includes:

Ancestry	Communities and occupations
Androids	Technical and medical work, including hazardous maintenance. Many bodies suit reduced gravity, but compatible components remain subject to Erbium leases and foundries.
Astrazoans	Administrative and public-facing work, including secure posts requiring obsolete identities or biometric clearances.
Brenneri	Aquatic communities with cooperative water systems and medical and social services. Their water requirements attract political scrutiny.
Fongon	Technical and financial analysis. Erbium uses their ability to process several problems at once to justify assigning multiple roles under one employment classification.
Lashuntas	Professional and public-facing services. Upper-district employers strongly favor expressions considered professionally desirable.
Madrosari	Specialist medicine and security work, including cybernetics and blood-reactive systems.
Moyishuu	Piloting and stellar observation, including emergency transport. Constellations visit frequently but often avoid settling in the enclosed cities.
Vesk	Heavy industry and dangerous external or emergency work.

Class, occupation, city, and sponsorship usually have more influence on daily security than ancestry. The **Human Default** still shapes design standards and public procedures.

LIFE IN SUSPENSION

Residents learn to recognize changes in the sound and operation of machinery around them. Children practice atmosphere drills alongside reading and arithmetic, and households keep masks accessible at every income level. On a lower deck, a sudden absence of machinery noise can warn of a stopped pump.

Public and industrial spaces often share compartments. Apartments fit around fixed braces, and community facilities occupy converted industrial space. Maintenance routes pass through housing built around older machinery. Residents personalize standardized interiors with decorations, small gardens, and repurposed equipment. Families keep objects from Wander and other homeworlds.

Older walls contain repairs and components from successive settlement periods, some dating back to Wander. Company emblems receive more consistent cleaning than the surrounding repairs.

BREATH, WATER, AND STATUS

Atmospheric equipment maintains breathable conditions through constant recycling and treatment. Housing assessments account for expected air demand, medical needs, occupancy, and evacuation priority. Residents pay through housing and service charges or employment deductions; access also depends on their medical and residential classifications.

Water supplies depend on imported ice, chemical production, and extensive recycling. Upper districts maintain ornamental gardens and water features in public spaces, which Erbium publicizes as evidence of successful settlement. Lower districts operate under strict water allotments and recycling requirements. Residential water needs compete with industrial and agricultural demand. Allocation disputes affect access to housing and employment, particularly for brenneri communities.

CORPORATE AND INDUSTRIAL ECONOMY

Theosis earns much of its wealth through corporate administration and intersystem finance. Its technical economy specializes in pressure habitats and the systems that support them, with major industries in sulfur chemistry and solar power. Transport services, specialized medicine, and professional education provide further income. The planet also administers the relay network and PES synchronization.

Wealthy institutions occupy spacious, quiet upper compartments with maintenance equipment hidden from public areas. Heavy machinery operates beneath them. On lower decks, the smell of hot machinery mixes with food cooked beside transit and maintenance routes.

Theosis-trained engineers work throughout the Settled Systems, wherever people depend on artificial environments. Recruitment campaigns feature these technicians' competence and sacrifice, usually omitting the ownership of the infrastructure they maintain.

PUBLIC RITUAL AND CORPORATE MEMORY

Second Home Day commemorates the early construction fleets and Erbium's declaration that it would rebuild a permanent home. Executive speeches and public celebrations honor the early settlers and Erbium's role in preserving civilization after Wander. Company emblems are illuminated across the upper cities.

Workers also keep less formal remembrances. **The Empty Berths** honors those left on Wander through empty seats at communal meals and unclaimed work tags at memorial walls. During **Separation Vigils**, cities dim exterior lights and surviving relatives read the names of those lost in detached districts over maintenance and emergency channels.

First Stamp marks the activation of PES and the end of the Zakaron war. Corporate ceremonies celebrate the beginning of shared intersystem civilization. Zakaron communities and political dissidents dispute that account.

MAJOR LOCATIONS

CROWN MERIDIAN

The oldest buoyant city, planetary capital, and formal seat of Erbium grew around a continuity frame built before Wander's destruction. Its original core still houses corporate archives and reserves alongside early settlement machinery. Government bodies and other major institutions occupy successive expansions. Communities in lower compartments maintain the frames and machinery supporting newer upper districts.

ERBIUM CENTRAL

The headquarters and planetary administration occupy Crown Meridian's upper structural core. Its facilities and role in government are described in the earlier **Erbium Central** section.

CONCORDANCE HALL

The Council of Settled Systems Administration meets in a central chamber surrounded by diplomatic offices and their support facilities. Erbium's permanent Stewardship Seat faces the rotating chair. Visitors can watch formal sessions from public galleries; most substantial agreements are negotiated beforehand in private technical committees.

PALLADIUM REACH

Crown Meridian's highest stable habitation tier houses its wealthiest residents and most prestigious institutions in connected pressure galleries. Its large interior volumes provide lift. Ballast systems below compensate for dense construction, private water reserves, and the gravitic stabilization used to maintain its preferred conditions.

THE KEELWORKS

Crown Meridian's lower industrial districts maintain the city's heavy infrastructure around the clock. Their large human workforce and dwarven clanholdings live in housing tied to that work, supported by worker institutions and independent repair markets.

TAVRAN BRACE

This dwarven clanholding and structural works spans several of Crown Meridian's oldest load-bearing frames. Clan Tavran keeps inspection and repair records from before PES, and its engineers refuse to approve work they cannot fully inspect. The holding provides members and affiliated workers with housing and support services.

SKINLINE FOURTEEN

Skinline Fourteen is an envelope-maintenance zone beneath the city Gannet. Crews work between the breathable inner membrane and corrosion-resistant outer skin, using protective equipment and continuous atmospheric monitoring. Housing within the industrial pressure compartment is classified as employment-adjacent. A single administrative action can terminate both a resident's job and immediate habitation eligibility.

OSPREY

Osprey is a semi-independent aerostat run through an elected Envelope Council, resident cooperative, and worker-owned maintenance authority. It controls housing and life support locally while buying relay service, medicine, and specialized parts from Erbium. The Free Altitude League cites it as evidence that municipal control is technically viable. Its stabilizer manufacturer has stopped selling directly to cooperatives.

THE CASTOFF FIELD

Detached city structures and the facilities used to salvage them drift in a relatively predictable lower-atmosphere current. Some structures were evacuated; others are memorial sites. Salvagers work from mobile pressure habitats while former owners and creditors dispute rights to the remaining property.

HELIOSTAT BASTION

This hardened solar array supports orbital facilities and maintains power reserves for planetary emergencies and Shredder preparations. Its photovoltaic fields, storage, and transmission equipment withstand changing stellar conditions. Radiation crews maintain replacement panels from dozens of production generations.

THEOSIS WAY STATION

The main orbital service and atmospheric-transfer facility houses about five hundred permanent personnel in rotating sections, with several times that population during traffic surges. Docking and service infrastructure surrounds the central structure. Shredder delays can leave travelers paying more for temporary lodging and cargo storage than their original passage cost.